



The savior of the internet

The untold story of the 23 year old hacker who pulled the plug on the WannaCry ransomware. <https://digit.in/jun20-124>



The office is dead

From startups to tech giants, everyone is evaluating whether they need office spaces any more. <https://digit.in/jun20-125>

FEATURE

FRIENDSTER

This is and perhaps one that everyone expects to be on this list. Before Facebook and Twitter and the likes there was Friendster. Started in 2003, Friendster was pretty much exactly what Facebook became – a place to make friends, share photos



Before Facebook and Twitter, there was Friendster

and videos and generally socialise across the internet. Friendster was an amalgamation of the words Friend and Napster (because Napster was hot at the time). Today, Friendster is a social gaming platform that's pretty popular in south-east Asia.

DRAGON NATURALLY SPEAKING

Remember all the trial versions and offers Digit gave out for Dragon Naturally Speaking back in the day? At the time it seemed like magic to be able to talk to your computer, it understanding you, and then noting down what you said. It wasn't as good as what we're used to today, and people would have to modify their accent to get Dragon NS to understand them, but it was definitely ahead of its time! While people aren't sitting around dictating letters to a PC anymore (are they?), we are using voice commands in our cars and homes a lot more than we ever did before. Dragon NS was certainly an early species in that chain of evolution of NLP software!

POLAVISION (1977)

While we all take for granted the ability to shoot a video on our phone

and then just watch it back immediately afterwards, or show it to friends (usually online), this is only a recent development... or is it?

Polaroid was known for innovation in the personal film industry, and Polavision was the first to try and fulfil the need of people to almost instantly playback what they had just recorded. The Polavision was a camera and player bundle that allowed people to do exactly what we mentioned above. And it flopped miserably; so miserably that just 2 years later, the Polavision was discontinued! The problem was the quality of the film capture, because of the method it used to self develop film. Back then,

8 mm film had to be sent off to professionals to be developed and then it would come back and be played on a projector.

Another problem with the system was that Polaroid was trying to be like Apple and tie you into their ecosystem. The videos shot on the Polavision camera could only be

played back on the Polavision player. No wonder it flopped!

PICTUREPHONE

Bell Systems released a device and service called the PicturePhone which they hoped to sell for \$165 a month back in 1964. That would be the equivalent of \$1000 or \$1200 in today's purchasing power. So obviously, not at all cheap! Still, there were people who could afford that amount in a day if they needed, so even if it was only the rich that were being targeted, there should have been some uptake of the technology. There was virtually none! It was like no one wanted to look at people when talking on the phone. It almost defeated the idea of a phone call, which was the ability to talk to someone without focussing on them with your eyes, thus freeing you up to do other things simultaneously. Plus if it was your mother-in-law on the phone, you wouldn't want her to see the faces you were making...

Interestingly, what Bell and later AT&T set out to do back in the late 60s and early 70s, was essentially to try and make a network of interconnected homes, all capable of sending video / data signals down their phone copper wires. Pretty much like what ADSL does in so many parts of the world, even today! In an attempt to launch a videophone service, AT&T almost built the Internet!

WEBTV (MSN TV)

Back in 1995, a company started off making these weird set top boxes, aimed at making your TV into a computer monitor of sorts. Think of it as an early attempt at making a smart TV. It caught the eye of Microsoft, who bought it and renamed it MSN TV, but even with Microsoft's power behind it, it still flopped. To be fair, it was not Microsoft's first flop and most certainly wasn't their last. In fact there are a few more Microsoft failures to come in this list itself. They're kind of known to be a company with brilliant vision in the consumer market, but with terrible



The Polavision was short lived